practitioners of a different religion; Hindus used to seeing various Hindus pursue their own modes of devotion found nothing odd in a people with their own different practices, assuming them to be just another kind of Hindu, until a wandering rabbi from Jerusalem arrived in India centuries later and identified them as the Jews they were.

It didn't matter to the Hindus around them. The *Haristuti* has a prayer that says: 'May Vishnu, the ruler of the three worlds, worshipped by the Shaivites as Shiva, by the Vedantins as Brahman, by the Buddhists as the Buddha, by the Naiyayikas as the chief agent, by the Jainas as the liberated, by the ritualists as the principle of *dharma*, may he grant our prayers.'[4] This cheerful eclecticism was the attitude that enabled Swami Vivekananda, concluding the presentation of a paper at Chicago's Parliament of the World's Religions in 1893, to call upon the blessings of 'He who is the Brahman of the Hindus, the Ahura Mazda of the Zoroastrians, the Buddha of the Buddhists, the Jehovah of the Jews, and the Father in Heaven of the Christians.' To him they were one and the same: 'That which exists is One; the sages call It by various names.'

SEEING LIFE WHOLE

The British, who in their two centuries of imperial rule over India struggled to understand and come to terms with Hinduism, did a great deal to explore and debate its meanings as best they could. Some saw it, in E. M. Forster's notorious phrase, as 'a mystery and a muddle'; others tried to reduce it to terms they could relate to. Whether Hinduism was polytheistic or monotheistic was a question that agitated many British minds. After the Census of 1911, one senior British official concluded that 'the great majority of Hindus have a firm belief in one supreme God —Parameshwara, Ishvara or Narayana.' The chief British census official in India, Sir Herbert Risley, observed that 'these ideas are not the monopoly of the learned: they are shared in great measure by the man on the street.' An 'intelligent Hindu peasant', he claimed, not only was familiar with Hindu concepts like the *paramatma* (supreme soul), *karma* (loosely translatable as 'fate'), *maya* (illusion), *mukti* (salvation) and so on, but had 'a rough working theory of their bearing upon his own future'.[5]